FADE IN.

INT. CONFERENCE ROOM - DAY

JACOB, 18, slouches at the head of the table - he would rather be anywhere else on his birthday. His dark, youthful features contrast his business suit. He doodles on a notepad.

JACOB
How much longer?

TROY, 50, Jacob's father, a light-haired, skinny man, makes eye contact with his wife, KAREN, across the table. Karen brushes a lock of red hair from her bony face. A gregarious LAWYER slides a heavy notebook to Troy.

LAWYER
Sign here and here please.

JACOB
Hello?

LAWYER
Now might actually be a good time for Jacob to excuse himself.

The Lawyer looks questioningly at Karen.

KAREN
No. He is fine right where he is.

JACOB
Yes, as if your divorce isn't enough. Please, more torture.

TROY
Sit up straight, son.

Jacob unenthusiastically complies.

LAWYER
(clearing his throat)
So. How do we want to handle the legalities of adoption?

JACOB
You guys are adopting a kid?

It's awkward.

TROY
Jacob, your mother and I decided that we would wait until your 18th birthday.

KAREN
I wasn't able to have my own children.

Jacob laughs. No one else does.

TROY
Jacob. Stop that.

Jacob immediately stops.

KAREN
Listen to us.

He turns to his mother.

KAREN (CONT'D)
We chose to tell you later rather than sooner.

Jacob, confused, looks down at his doodle.

BEGIN FLASHBACK MONTAGE

EXT. PLAYGROUND - DAY

Jacob, 7, swings. A female CLASSMATE stares at him as he swings toward and away from her.

CLASSMATE
Are you adopted?

INT. JACOB'S LIVING ROOM - NIGHT

Jacob, 10, turns pages in a antiqued family photo album. In every picture he is the only member of the family with brown hair.

INT. JACOB'S HOME STAIRCASE - NIGHT

Jacob, 13, sits on the top stair. He overhears a conversation from below.

AUNT
He’s a teenager now. I can’t believe he still doesn’t know.

UNCLE
I’ve been telling you, that side of your family has always been a little off.

END FLASHBACK MONTAGE

INT. CONFERENCE ROOM - CONTINUOUS

Jacob stands up violently. His chair crashes to the floor.

JACOB
All these years I’ve pretended to be part of this family. And all these years I shouldn’t have cared.

TROY
No, son. It’s been a great adoption.

JACOB
Maybe for you. I do everything you guys ask...tell me to do.

KAREN
Jacob don’t yell like that.

JACOB
(whispering)
This is unbelievable.

Jacob stands up straighter realizing his parents are ordering him around once again.

JACOB (CONT’D)
(yelling)
Am I even who I think I am? Who the hell are my real parents?

He stares menacingly at Karen and Troy. The Lawyer slides a manila envelope to him. He turns it open and skims.

Karen and Troy stare at each other, hoping the end is near.

Jacob spots a picture underneath the paperclip. It is his real Mom and Dad holding baby Jacob, smiling genuinely.

JACOB (CONT’D)
Is that me?

Troy nods.

JACOB (CONT'D)
Who are they?

KAREN
Your biological parents.

In Jacob's eye, we see the reflection of the photo.

He angrily grabs the envelope and storms towards the door.

TROY
Jacob, listen! Get back here!

Jacob turns around and starts back to the table. Midway, he stops in his tracks, shakes his head, and spins towards the door again.

KAREN
Jacob!

Jacob shoves the door open, spilling coffee on a young OFFICE GIRL.

JACOB (O.S.)
Let me guess, you're my biological sister?

Karen, Troy, and the Lawyer look at each other.

LAWYER
That went well.

EXT. CHARLESTON, SOUTH CAROLINA - DAY

Jacob bikes down a wooden dock. Coffee stains mark his shirt. He reaches the end and drops his bike carelessly on top of another bike.

MAXWELL, 18, floats face down in the dark water. Jacob picks up a small rock and throws it at Maxwell. Maxwell, sporting a snorkeling mask, jerks his head up.

MAXWELL
Dude!

His shaggy hair falls around his mask. He looks as though he could be Jacob's brother without the saddened eyes.

JACOB
I can't fucking believe it.

MAXWELL
What?

JACOB
You gotta read this.

MAXWELL
Now?

JACOB
Now.

MAXWELL
But the clams.

JACOB
They’re not moving any time soon.

Maxwell blows bubbles in the water, thinking.

MAXWELL
You owe me dinner.

JACOB
You cook it.

MAXWELL
Fine.

Maxwell swims to the dock and pulls himself out. He drapes a towel around his body and slides his mask over his dripping bangs.

Jacob pulls the manila envelope out of his backpack and hands it to Maxwell. Their legs dangle over the water. Maxwell flips through the pages.

A wooden CRACK is heard from a smaller dock to the right. Jacob looks. A large boat struggles to dock, reversing and accelerating into the dock.

MAXWELL (CONT’D)
No way this is real.

BEGIN FLASHBACK MONTAGE

-MR. & MRS. MUELEN, Jacob’s biological parents, eat dinner in their elaborately decorated dining room while a baby Jacob sits in a high chair. Pureed carrots dribble from his mouth.

-Mr. Muelen shakes hands with a man in a dimly lit basement.

-Mr. & Mrs. Muelen sit in their Mercedes-Benz at a stoplight. A robust, mustached MAN, appears from the backseat and shoots them both.

-The MAN sits courtside next to his lawyer. On the other side of the courtroom, a baby Jacob sits next to a lawyer.

JUDGE
Mr. Mellonde, I will hereby now remand you into the custody of the state of South Carolina for a term not to exceed life, without the possibility of parole.

The gavel is struck.

-Karen and Troy, dressed formally, set a baby Jacob in his crib. They kiss.

KAREN
He is precious.

-1 YEAR LATER: A gang member of Mr. Mellonde pays off the prison warden. They shake hands.

SLOW MOTION:

-Mr. Mellonde, the epitome of Man, grins as he exits the prison. His gang entourage follows.

END FLASHBACK MONTAGE

EXT. CHARLESTON - CONTINUOUS

JACOB
Oh, its real alright.

Maxwell closes the envelope. Water laps at the dock posts.

JACOB (CONT'D)
I want to find this Mr. Mellonde.

MAXWELL
Dude, why?

JACOB
He killed my real parents, that's why.

MAXWELL
So?

JACOB
I just want to know who he is. Why does he have the arrogance to do that?

MAXWELL
He doesn't even know you.

JACOB
I want to know him.

MAXWELL
Whatever. How the hell are you even going to pull that off? It says he legally changed his name. Plus, what would you even do if you saw him?

JACOB
It doesn't matter. I just gotta see his face.

MAXWELL
Man, you've been 18 years without this fucker. You straight.

Jacob stares ahead.

JACOB
I just need to Maxwell. Whether you're in or not.

MAXWELL
Shit, man.

Maxwell looks defeated.

MAXWELL (CONT'D)
Well we could try digging up some police records but, I don't know man, those things are on lockdown.

JACOB
(standing up)
Let's go.

MAXWELL
Right no...

JACOB
(interrupting)
Yes. Come on.